
"Euphoria" Is a Spectacle

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“ ‘Euphoria’ is a big, vulgar, carnivalesque thing,” Naomi Fry writes, “an extreme, often-disgusting vision of a rapacious, pitiless America where everyone is fighting for scraps.” Sound fun? The season’s second episode is out tonight. Plus:

- [Why David Sedaris kept his marriage a secret](#)
 - [Victor Wembanyama has taken over basketball](#)
 - [A guide to getting rid of almost everything](#)
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Visual by Bina Thorsen; Source video courtesy HBO Max

Hannah Jocelyn

Newsletter editor

Season 3 of “Euphoria” has arrived, and with it comes a swirl of discourse. It’s been four years since the previous season; have the actors outgrown their breakout roles? Where do we find their characters, and what might this go-round mean for them? I turned to our critic Naomi Fry for answers to these and other questions; [she reviewed this season](#), and we recently spoke about how it is a departure from the first two and how the show’s world has been sensationalized. “Levinson is looking to engage with what America is, exactly,” she writes. “And let me tell you: right now, it’s really not looking great.”

Our conversation has been edited and condensed.

This season already feels like it’s doing a lot. Is “Euphoria” poised to jump the shark?

I don’t think so. I know that the critical response, so far at least, has seemed kind of disappointed. It’s not what people were expecting based on the first two seasons, which were maybe more sensitive or introspective or emotional—more aligned with the canonical idea of what a teen drama should be, in which young characters are searching, confused, depressed and undergo some kind of change through their relationships with their friends. Even the second season, which ratcheted up the tits and the ass and the crazy, and had a sort of laughing-while-the-world-ends vibe, still had some psychological depth, even if it was slightly less at the forefront than in the first season.

This season has more of what I think Levinson is good at—the set pieces, the kicks. It's more porny and action-packed. It's not going to teach us anything about what people are really like, but I kind of enjoy it for what it is—at least the first three episodes, which are all I've been given access to so far. It's ambitious and audacious. Let's call it a spectacle.

What do you attribute that tonal shift to?

It probably has to do with the fact that these characters are no longer teens. Five years have passed and they're kind of hardened by the real world. They're getting down to business, and the real business—for all of them—is making money. That's, ultimately, what this season is about.

Levinson wants his characters to get their bag—no matter the cost.

The world he portrays is awful. Everyone is selling their body. Everybody is hot, everybody has fake boobs. It's very much, like, let's cut to the chase, this is what Americans want. We want strippers, we want drugs, we want money, we want guns. Showcasing these values is absolutely nightmarish. It is not a good world that we're living in, and that the show is putting forth. I was joking to my editor that the headline of the review should be “We Live in Hell.”

Do the characters know they're in hell?

There's a moment when a strip-club owner is telling Rue that he's created his own little slice of heaven, and Rue later remarks that if God grants her her wish, she, too, will have a little slice of heaven like this one someday. But what is very clear is that it's literal hell. These girls are dying of overdoses, they're being disappeared and trafficked. It's incredibly dangerous and scary, as Rue quickly learns—although that doesn't dissuade her.

I thought Zendaya as Rue did some pretty incredible acting in the first episode. What do you think?

My general take would be to say that “Euphoria” is really not about the acting this season. It's about the cinematic quality—the vistas of Texas, Mexico, California—the atmosphere, and the visuals. If you're looking for sensitive individual performances, you're in the wrong place. Come instead for the spectacle.

Editor's Pick



Personal History

Why I Wanted to Keep My Marriage a Secret

It's not that I was embarrassed by Hugh or that I thought someone better might come along. I just shudder when I hear a man say the words "my husband."

By David Sedaris

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The Sporting Scene

The Spurs Are the Most Exciting Team in the N.B.A.

Despite a string of injuries, Victor Wembanyama, San Antonio's star center, has helped energize a young, gifted roster. Is a championship on the horizon?

By Louisa Thomas



The New Yorker Interview

How the Creator of “Beef” Got from Petty Feuds to Class Warfare

Lee Sung Jin on tailoring dialogue to Oscar Isaac and Charles Melton, the differences between Korean and American élites, and making TV in an age of “all-gas, no-brakes capitalism.”

By Inkoo Kang



Fiction

“Ordinary Wear and Tear”

She broke Carl’s heart, he thought, but she’s not breaking mine.

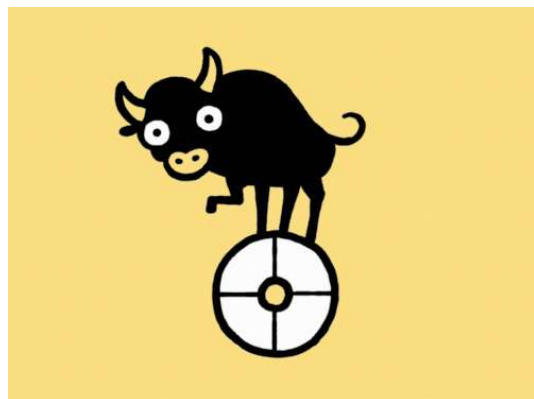
By Thomas McGuane



Shuffalo

Play Shuffalo

Can you make a longer word with each new letter?



In Case You Missed It



Letter from New Orleans



On and Off the Avenue

The Car-Crash Conspiracy

High-speed accidents, crooked lawyers, and poor people desperate for cash—it was the kind of scheme that could have been cooked up only in the Big Easy.

By Patrick Radden Keefe

A Guide to Getting Rid of Almost Everything

Once you've thanked and said goodbye to the items that do not spark joy, what can you do with them?

By Patricia Marx



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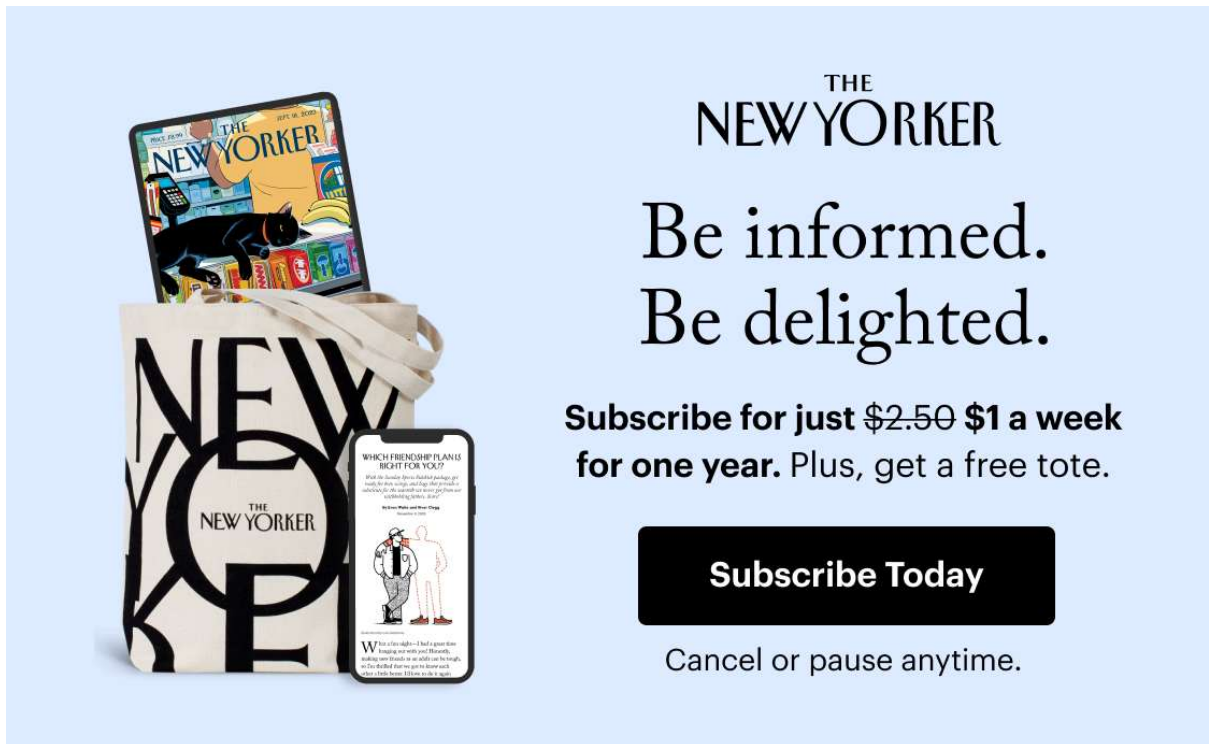


Cartoon by Julia Thomas

“Did you procrastinate at work by reading the menu and deciding what to order, or do you need a few more minutes?”

[See more cartoons](#)

P.S. Cherry blossoms in New York. Jacarandas in L.A. The trees are blooming across the country; if you are picnicking, be careful of descending flowers. As [the haiku master Basho observed](#), “From all these trees—in salads, soups, everywhere—cherry blossoms fall.” □



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